Mastering Observability

ADVISORY · STRATEGY · PRACTICE

SAMPLE STRATEGY · MASTERING OBSERVABILITY

The Ashcombe Observability Strategy: member requests, within the time we promised.

An observability strategy for Ashcombe Life & Pensions, written the way a client receives one: the diagnosis, the guiding policy, the first ninety days, the four years they begin, and how the board will know it worked.

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ILLUSTRATIVE · ASHCOMBE LIFE & PENSIONS IS A FICTIONAL ORGANISATION · NO CLIENT'S DATA · EVERY FIGURE IS ILLUSTRATIVE

AT A GLANCE

Can Ashcombe complete member requests within the timescale it promises, and explain why when it does not?

01 **The promise breaks in the gaps between teams**
A transfer crosses five systems and three teams, and nobody owns the whole journey.

02 **Nobody can see a request from start to finish**
Each team watches its own system. Nobody watches the member's request.

03 **One journey, one owner, one quarter**
Transfers first, owned end to end by a named person.

04 **No tool selection in the first year**
The first ninety days use what Ashcombe already runs.

05 **The board sees a funnel, not a dashboard**
Requests in, completed, stopped or failed, and how long completion took.

1 Diagnosis
2 Guiding policy
3 Coherent actions
4 Years one to four
5 How the board will know

HOW THIS WAS SOURCED

Ashcombe Life & Pensions does not exist. It is a composite built to show the shape of a real strategy, and every figure in it is illustrative. The method is Allan Mann's own practice and Metrics & Mayhem. No client's facts, figures or documents are used.

1 · DIAGNOSIS

Member requests break in the gaps between teams

Ashcombe Life & Pensions is a mid-sized UK life and pensions provider, with around 900,000 members across workplace and personal pensions. Its digital front end is five years old. The policy administration underneath it is more than twenty. The board keeps hearing one complaint: member requests miss the timescales Ashcombe promises. Transfers in and out, changes to drawdown, the paperwork when a member dies.

Every team at Ashcombe is meeting its own targets. The member is still waiting.

> How this diagnosis was done. It's really important for me to understand what the teams actually do. On site or online, I sit with them, look at their day and shadow them as closely as I can, to see where the gaps really are. That gives me the business flow before anything else.

Two weeks of sitting with the front-end, administration and payments teams, following one journey: a transfer out. What that showed, set out as the five-minute test:

The outcome: transfers completed within the timescale Ashcombe promises: ten working days, counted from a complete request to payment. Time spent waiting on the member or the receiving scheme is shown separately.

The signals that can move it: the online submission, scam and due-diligence checks, the administration queue, document handling, payment to the receiving scheme, and a manual exceptions queue.

What Ashcombe can see today: the front end and the payments. The administration queue lives in a weekly operations report. The exceptions queue is a shared mailbox.

Who owns the join: nobody. Each team owns its stage. The member's request belongs to whoever picks it up.

The last breach: a batch of transfers sat in the exceptions mailbox for six working days. The member found out first, by phoning.

Source: illustrative, fictional organisation

2 · GUIDING POLICY

One journey, one owner, and no shopping list

One journey first. Transfers out, because they carry the most complaints and cross the most teams. Drawdown changes come next, then the paperwork when a member dies. One at a time, each proved before the next starts.

One owner. A named person owns the transfer journey from submission to payment: the member's request, not any one system. Every team keeps its stage. The owner holds the join.

What we will not do. This is a strategy document. We agree the deliverable first: what the strategy is and what it looks like. Tool selection is not part of it, at least not in the first draft. So the first ninety days use what Ashcombe already runs. A platform decision, if one is needed, comes later and is argued from what the first year shows.

The regulator's language. Journeys like these are the kind a firm names as important business services under the UK's operational resilience rules, each with an impact tolerance: the most disruption the firm will tolerate. The promised timescale is a natural early-warning line inside it, so the strategy reports in terms the board already uses.

3 · COHERENT ACTIONS

Ninety days, one journey, five moves

Each move follows from the diagnosis. None of them needs a purchase order.

1 WEEKS 1 AND 2
Name the owner. One person, by name, owns transfers end to end, and the board gives that person the authority to ask any team for change.

2 WEEKS 3 AND 4
Finish the map. Close the gaps the diagnosis left open, until every hand-off and all six signals are on one map of the transfer, from submission to payment.

3 WEEKS 5 TO 8
Make every request visible end to end. Join the signals Ashcombe already collects so one transfer can be followed through every stage, including the exceptions mailbox.

4 WEEKS 9 TO 11
Fix the first gap. The exceptions queue gets an owner, a time limit and an alert to a person who can act on it.

5 WEEK 12
First board readout. The transfer funnel, the completion time, and the choice of the next journey.

At day 90: a named owner for transfers; every transfer visible from submission to payment; the exceptions queue watched; the board funnel live; the next journey chosen.

> **Built for AI, in the right order.** This is an observability strategy, not an AI programme. Most boards now ask where AI fits, and in this strategy it fits from the start, as the reason for the order of the work rather than a purchase. The first year puts in what AI needs to be useful and safe: one standard for the data, a named owner for every journey, and a funnel that shows what normal looks like. That groundwork is what lets AI help Ashcombe move faster later without making mistakes faster. The aim for year three is AI preparing the triage note for the person who gets the call. By year four, every automation and every decision AI makes has a named owner.

4 · YEARS ONE TO FOUR

Every level of maturity has an outcome behind it

Plenty of vendor maturity models stop at the label. A level on a slide, and nothing behind it. This one is written for Ashcombe, and each year is judged by what is true at the end of it.

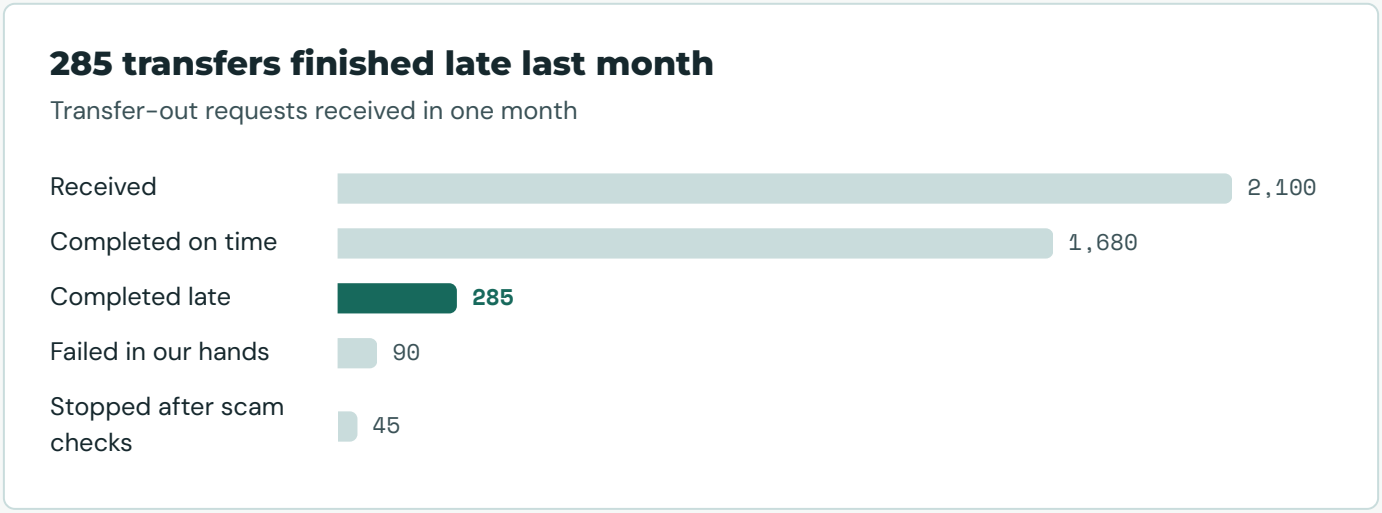
YEAR	WHAT IS TRUE AT THE END OF IT
Year 1 **Foundation** Committed	Transfers, drawdown changes and the paperwork when a member dies each have a named owner and a funnel the board reads. One open standard for telemetry, OpenTelemetry, is adopted on those journeys, and the teams are trained in it. No new tools and no new agents. By the end of the year Ashcombe knows where its tools overlap and where the real gaps are, and its incident reporting is ready before the FCA's rules apply on 18 March 2027.
Year 2 **Operational** Planned	Important business services come in through one onboarding route, team by team, each team with agreed targets, alert noise first. Where year one proved an overlap, a tool retires. Where it proved a gap, the gap is filled. The regulator's evidence comes from the same view the board reads.
Year 3 **Assisted** Direction	When something breaks, the person who gets the call starts with a triage note, built by AI from every signal on the journey and sorted by blast radius. Routine fixes start to be automated, through the service desk Ashcombe already uses.
Year 4 **Reciprocal** Direction	The system keeps itself current. Runbooks change when the service changes. New monitoring and new journeys come in through the standard. Alerting and ownership are reviewed as routine. Every automation, and every decision AI makes, has a named person who owns it.

Source: FCA PS26/2, operational incident and third party reporting, March 2026; every other detail illustrative

Year one is a commitment. Year two is the plan. Years three and four are direction, reviewed every year against what the funnel shows. The ninety-day plan rolls on: each quarter takes its next moves from the year it sits in.

The board sees one funnel per journey

For each journey, the completion time and the items in and out: how many completed, how many were stopped, how many failed. One funnel and one time, read in one glance, the same shape for every journey as it joins.



Source: illustrative, fictional organisation

16 working days

AVERAGE FOR THE TRANSFERS THAT FINISHED LATE, AGAINST A PROMISE OF TEN

Source: illustrative, fictional organisation

At the first readout the board sees the month's 375 missed promises: 285 late and 90 failed in Ashcombe's hands. Transfers stopped after scam checks are counted apart, because stopping them was the right outcome. By the second readout the board can see whether the owner's first fix moved the number.

WHERE THIS BREAKS

It fails in three ways, all avoidable

The owner has a title and no authority. If the person who owns the transfer journey cannot ask the administration or payments teams to change anything, the role is decoration. The board grants that authority in week 1, in writing.

The view becomes another dashboard. If nobody acts on what it shows, it joins the others on the wall. It stays alive because the owner reviews it every week and the board reads its funnel every month.

Ninety days turns into a platform project. The moment the conversation becomes which tool to buy, the strategy has stopped. The policy says no tool selection in this phase, and the board holds the line.

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

Ashcombe is fictional. Your journeys are not.

01 **Pick the journey your customers complain about most.** One, not a portfolio.

02 **Ask who owns it end to end.** A person, by name. If nobody can answer, that is the first finding.

03 **Ask how long the last breach took to notice.** And who noticed first: your team, or your customer.

THE ONE ASK

Book a free 30-minute review.

Bring one journey your customers complain about. Thirty minutes with me on what its strategy would look like, free.

calendar.app.google/y2wSmwhGrkf8r5Xv5